



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Cincinnati Classical Academy

School Website: <https://cincyclassical.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Cincinnati Classical Academy (Oh 45215) presents a robust classical-education program across its public-facing materials. Using the Six Essential Elements framework, the school demonstrates clear classical commitments in most domains, with Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations) and Element 2 (School Purpose and Goal) and Element 3 (Curriculum) and Element 4 (Pedagogy) and Element 5 (Faculty) and Element 6 (Parents & Community) aligning strongly with classical aims. The site emphasizes virtue, truth, goodness, beauty, Great Books, liberal-arts pedagogy, Socratic dialogue, memorization/recitation, and a living, teacher-led culture. The school also stresses formation of character and civic virtue, a content-rich liberal-arts curriculum, and partnerships with families. Some elements—such as explicit liturgical/theological practices—are less overt on public pages, though the mission and pedagogy strongly reflect classical aims. Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Key insights:

- Strong emphasis on virtue, wisdom, and formation over mere information; frequent allusions to truth, goodness, beauty, and the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Great Books. This aligns with classical aims in Categories 2, 3, 4, 5, and 6, yielding CLASSICAL across most domains. Evidence includes explicit statements about moral character, civic virtue, and a content-rich classical curriculum, supported by pages such as *What is Classical Education?* and *Mission/Headmaster communications*.
- Pedagogy is distinctly classical (Socratic dialogue, memorization/recitation, rhetoric, teacher-led instruction, and conscious cultivation of memory and virtue). Public materials repeatedly describe these methods (e.g., “we diagram sentences, we read the great and difficult books, we memorize and recite poetry, we do mathematical proofs”).
- Curriculum centers on Great Books, primary sources, grammar–logic–rhetoric (Trivium), Latin, and a liberal-arts approach, with explicit emphasis on the Classics and Western tradition. Positive indicators include references to Great Books, primary sources, Latin, and classical curricula.
- Family/Community partnership and parent involvement are foregrounded (e.g., *Our Mission/Our Vision* emphasize parental partnership and moral formation at home, plus a culture of parent engagement). This supports Element 6 as CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials foreground truth, goodness, and beauty as enduring aims of education and emphasize moral formation and virtue (e.g., “An education at Cincinnati Classical Academy... aims to cultivate human virtue” and emphasizes objective standards of truth, beauty, and virtue).
- The school highlights civic virtue and moral formation (core virtues and character formation are repeatedly named).
- Core Virtues page outlines prudence, justice, courage, humility, gratitude, perseverance, and compassion as foundational traits.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords found: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; moral order; moral formation; ordered affections; wisdom; telos. (Derived from multiple pages showing ethics, virtue, and the moral aims of education.)

- Negative keywords present: minimal explicit signaling of relativism or secularism in public-facing content; no strong negative signals detected in the school's materials.
- Estimated balance: Predominantly positive signals; essentially zero negative signals observed in public materials.
- Why this rating
- The materials consistently present transcendental-evocation language (truth, goodness, beauty) and moral formation as aims of education, with explicit virtue-based language and a focus on moral character and civic virtue. This aligns with TRANScendental Moral Realism and the role of virtue in education, even if explicit liturgical rituals are less visible on public pages. CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Mission/Headmaster communications frame education as formation of character and intellect, aiming for human flourishing and virtue, not merely job preparation. The mission emphasizes forming the mind and heart through a content-rich classical liberal-arts curriculum with moral/civic formation.
- Public statements describe education as formation and the cultivation of virtue and wisdom, not only information, with references to the Western tradition and timeless aims.
- The school describes “formation of the will” and pursuit of the good, true, and beautiful as aims of education (language clearly reflecting classical telos).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords found: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, scholé (contemplation/rest), great conversation, classical heritage, human flourishing.
- Negative keywords present: minimal explicit emphasis on 21st-century workforce readiness; content does not foreground work-readiness as primary telos.
- Estimated balance: Strong positive signals; essentially no negative signals in public content.
- Why this rating
- The school's published aims center on formation, virtue, wisdom, and the great conversation, consistent with CLASSICAL goals; less emphasis on vocational or job-readiness as the primary telos. CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Explicit commitment to Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) as foundational, along with Great Books/primary sources, and a “Great Conversation” approach. The materials emphasize a liberal-arts curriculum rich in classic texts and primary sources.
- Strong focus on reading the classics, Western canon, and literature that shapes Western civilization (Reading the Classics; Great Books / primary sources).
- Latin study, explicit phonics, grammar and composition instruction, and a robust classics-forward science/language sequence appear in public materials.
- Hillsdale 1776 Curriculum and Core Knowledge references appear as part of the content sequence, indicating a curriculum anchored in historical classical traditions and knowledge content.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords found: liberal arts; Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric); Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy); Great Books; primary sources; Latin; history; classical canon; virtue ethics; natural philosophy; science through a liberal-arts lens; memory work (recitation).
- Negative keywords present: occasional references to “project-based learning dominance” or “STEM-first framing” in the knowledge-base lexicon, but the school's own public materials emphasize classical content-heavy approaches more than those critical negative signals would suggest.
- Estimated balance: Predominantly positive signals; minimal explicit negative signals in the school's own public materials.
- Why this rating
- The curriculum is clearly anchored in the liberal-arts tradition and Great Books, with explicit reference to grammar–logic–rhetoric, primary sources, Latin, and a classical canon; this aligns strongly with

CLASSICAL expectations. CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Multiple public-facing pages describe Socratic dialogue and dialectic, seminars, and rhetoric as central pedagogical modes; recitation/memorization and a living, teacher-led approach are emphasized. The language includes “Socratic dialogue,” “Seminar,” “recitation,” “memory work,” and “teacher-led classrooms.”
- The pedagogy includes restful learning (Scholé) and contemplation as a component of education; lower-school activities include singing/chanting to deepen memory.
- Explicit references to the Great Books approach, dialectic, and the “living curriculum” concept imply a pedagogy that centers on models of excellence and classical instruction.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords found: Socratic dialogue; dialectic; Socratic seminars; narration; recitation; chanting; singing; memory work; liturgical or ritual recitation; restfulness (Scholé); master-teacher modeling; rhetoric; speeches.
- Negative keywords present: Minimal public signals of purely student-centered or project-based pedagogy (which are listed as negatives in the classical lexicon). The site consistently foregrounds teacher-led, memory-based, and dialogic approaches.
- Estimated balance: Strong positive signals; negligible negative signals.
- Why this rating
- The site’s explicit promotion of Socratic/dialogic methods, memory-based pedagogy, and teacher-led instruction aligns with CLASSICAL pedagogy. CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The publications and pages emphasize teachers as living exemplars and the core of the school’s culture; mentions of master teachers, mentors, and a “living curriculum” highlight the faculty as central to the school’s classical mission. Examples include language such as “the living curriculum” and “portrait of a teacher.”
- There are explicit references to faculty leadership, teacher-student mentorship, and a culture of intellectual tradition; the Headmaster’s communications repeatedly foreground educator leadership and classical training.
- The Hillsdale/Hillsdale-affiliated content suggests teachers trained in classical pedagogy with a shared mission, and the school emphasizes that teachers craft lessons with strength, virtue, and rigor.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords found: living curriculum; master teachers; mentors; portrait of a teacher; teacher-led classrooms; classical pedagogy; virtue formation; lifelong learners.
- Negative keywords present: Negatives such as “facilitators” or “guides on the side” are not evidenced in public materials; no significant negative signals appeared.
- Estimated balance: Strong positive signals; minimal negative indicators.
- Why this rating
- The public-facing content consistently positions faculty as the core of the classical education enterprise, with emphasis on teacher-led, virtuous, and wise instruction. CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school’s mission and vision explicitly frame parents as partners in education, with emphasis on parent formation, home-school partnership, and open-campus engagement. There are multiple references to co-teaching models and parent involvement in school life.
- Community-building language and parent-connected initiatives (e.g., a planned Parent Service Organization, volunteering opportunities, involvement in athletics, and clubs) appear in public materials.
- The “Our Coat of Arms & Motto” and other pages emphasize shared mission and family engagement in a classical tradition.

- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords found: partnership with families; parent formation; open campus; parental involvement; family formation; home-school collaboration; shared mission; parental leadership; community support.
- Negative keywords present: The lexicon mentions potential negative signals like “parent as customer” or limited parental involvement; the school’s materials do not use consumer-focused language; rather, they emphasize active parental partnership.
- Estimated balance: Strong positive signals; no clear negative signals in the public domain.
- Why this rating
- The school’s materials consistently present parents as co-teachers and partners in a classical education framework, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for parent/community involvement. CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Assessment

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL.
- Rationale: Across all six categories, Cincinnati Classical Academy’s public materials substantially align with the classical-education rubric: virtues and formation; content-rich liberal-arts curriculum; memory-based and dialogic pedagogy; a faculty-centered living curriculum; and robust parental partnership. The strongest alignment appears in Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents & Community, with formation-focused language pervading School Purpose and Goal and Religious/Metaphysical Foundations. While explicit liturgical/theological practices are not widely foregrounded on public pages, transcendental aims (truth, goodness, beauty) and virtue-based formation are consistently emphasized.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not required given the CLASSICAL aggregate rating.
- If one wanted to further strengthen the Classical alignment, considerations could include:
- Explicitly naming theology/liturgical practices or sacramental/morally formative dimensions within the curriculum to more clearly meet Liturgical and Communal Practices.
- Regularly featuring a more explicit Great Books sequence and primary-source reading lists per grade level to reinforce the Great Conversation in every division.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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